



Powering intelligence through data: From collection to connection

Learn how to build an intelligence-led organisation by uniting data, tech and teams to move from data collection to real-time connection and action.

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Powering intelligence through data

In today's data-saturated world, the problem isn't collection – it's connection. Brands are drowning in data, but starving for intelligence. With 68% of enterprise data going unused ([IDC](#)), the intelligence gap is now the biggest threat to business performance – and the biggest opportunity. Powering intelligence means going beyond fragmented insights and siloed tools to build a unified system where data, teams, and technology work seamlessly together, enabling faster, smarter, and more strategic decisions rooted in meaningful insight.

This paper explores what it takes to become an intelligence-led organisation, and why it's no longer a nice-to-have, but a business imperative. From evolving customer expectations to rising complexity across channels and platforms, brands today must be able to anticipate change, not just react to it. Yet 79% of CMOs say they struggle to

use data to predict future propositions ([dentsu](#)). The gap between data collection and value creation remains wide.

We outline five key forces that define intelligence in action: actionable understanding, deep awareness, strategic clarity, predictive capability, and competitive edge; and three organisational imperatives that enable them: connected teams, connected tech, and a culture of intelligence.

Drawing on interviews with data and marketing leaders, global research, and brand case studies, this paper offers a practical roadmap to powering intelligence,

For businesses looking to move from data-driven to truly intelligence-led, the future starts here. Read on to uncover more.

What's at stake – and why now

The advent of cloud computing has meant storage is cheap, and yet cheap data storage has a hidden cost: companies store too much data that has limited business value. Too many organisations still treat data as something to collect, rather than connect.

In today's always-on environment, brands are inundated with data. Every customer interaction, campaign touchpoint, and digital signal adds to an ever-expanding mountain of information – much of it gathered without a clear plan for how it will be used. But more isn't always better. To drive real value, brands must move away from indiscriminate data collection and focus instead on gathering only the insights they need to power action.

The ability to connect, analyse and activate intelligence across teams, platforms and customer touchpoints is now the primary battleground for growth. And yet, Merkle research has shown:



95% of employees
feel overwhelmed by data



55% of data
is siloed and fragmented



50% of marketers
are using AI passively or not at all

Add to this the pressure of privacy shifts, spiralling data storage costs, and rising AI expectations, and it's clear: **data alone is no longer a differentiator.** Intelligence is. It's what will separate brands that thrive from those that stall.

Many businesses are overwhelmed by their own complexity: siloed teams, fragmented tools, legacy systems and inconsistent KPIs all make it difficult to turn data into impact. Even when the right data exists, it's often inaccessible, mistrusted, or simply not used.

Powering intelligence is about turning that passive posture into active advantage. It's the difference between data that describes the past and intelligence that shapes the future. And it's a shift that defines the next era of competitive growth.

Why intelligence matters now

Data alone doesn't drive better decisions – connection that fuels intelligence does. Yet most organisations fail to operationalise the value of the information they hold. According to [IDC](#), around 68% of enterprise data goes unused, representing a massive opportunity for brands to unlock untapped value. At the same time, 82% of CMOs say monitoring changes in the consumer environment is their biggest challenge – underscoring the need to act faster and smarter with the data already available ([Global CMO Navigator: CXM Edition, dentsu](#)).

In fact, customer data-driven campaigns generate 38% more response effects, 25% more business effects, and deliver 14% higher ROI than average ([The Value of Customer Data, DMA](#)). These effects are not just short-term – they're essential proof points that show how intelligence can bridge the gap between data and decisive action.

With intelligence comes the ability to use data to anticipate what's next, align cross-functional teams, and act with confidence. With consumers considering fewer sources when making purchase decisions (on average just 2.5 sources per purchase) the margin for error has never been smaller ([Engagement to Empowerment: Winning in Today's Experience Economy, Merkle](#)).

“True intelligence isn't about chasing every new AI tool. It's about solving the real customer problems with precision.”

– Sunny Ng, Data Activation and Measurement Lead, Colgate

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of enterprise data

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From instinct to intelligence:

Five forces for better decision-making

Through interviews with senior marketers, CDOs and data strategists, we've identified five forces that define an intelligence-led organisation:

1. ACTIONABLE UNDERSTANDING

It's not enough just to have data; it must be timely, relevant and usable. Isabel Palmer, AI Champion/ Director for Experian EMS UK Engineering, told us: "AI can simplify and accelerate the process of transforming data into relevant, high-quality, secure, and accessible assets."* But insight is only powerful when it drives action. For example, in Merkle's report, [Engagement to Empowerment: Winning in Today's Experience Economy](#), CX leaders cited real-time performance dashboards as a key enabler of faster commercial decisions.

Actionable understanding ensures data drives value, not just reporting.

2. DEEP AWARENESS

This means understanding customers, markets and competitors in context. Today's consumers expect experiences that are not just functional but aligned with their values. In fact, 35% of UK consumers now prefer to buy from brands with a strong purpose – up 8% since 2022 ([Read the Room](#):

* The views and opinions expressed in this article are those of the author and do not necessarily reflect the official policy, position, or views of Experian.



[Pursuing Happiness, dentsu](#)). And 80% of global consumers say the best way to earn their loyalty is to surprise and delight them in unexpected ways. (Consumer Vision 2035, dentsu).

To meet rising expectations, brands need a values-led, data-informed view of what truly matters to their audiences.

3. STRATEGIC CLARITY

Intelligence-led brands are able to synthesise fragmented inputs into connected experiences. But 79% of CMOs say they still struggle to use data to predict future products and propositions ([Global CMO Navigator: CXM Edition, dentsu](#)).

CX leaders, however, are more likely to align around long-term KPIs like customer lifetime value, not just short-term efficiency metrics ([Winning in today's experience economy: What CX leaders do differently, Merkle](#)).

Strategic clarity bridges the gap between knowing and doing.

4. PREDICTIVE CAPABILITY

Real-time signals should shape tomorrow's decisions. "Nissan's use of conjoint analytics to assess pricing sensitivity is a powerful example of how customer experience intelligence can directly inform product and pricing strategy," said Jivesh Juneja, Head of Data Products, Nissan. "By understanding how consumers weigh different features and trade-offs, we can make smarter, faster decisions that align with market expectations."

Predictive capability turns customer signals into competitive foresight.

"The organisations that thrive will be those that move beyond tools and instead build insight-driven, custom solutions that deliver measurable value."

– Marco Iannone, Group Head of AI, Allwyn (operator of the UK's National Lottery)

70%

of consumers

expect AI to play a role in most aspects of their lives by 2035.

5. COMPETITIVE EDGE

Intelligence creates responsiveness, and the agility to act when it matters most. Our research shows that CX leaders are more likely to centralise their data, embed it across functions, and link it to performance; a key marker of future-readiness ([Winning in today's experience economy: What CX leaders do differently, Merkle](#)).

Intelligence-led brands outpace competitors because they can see – and seize – opportunity first.

From ambition to action: Three imperatives to power intelligence

Translating intelligence into impact doesn't happen by chance. It requires deliberate design across structure, systems, and culture. Through our work with leading brands and insights from marketing and data leaders, we've identified three core imperatives that consistently enable organisations to move from ambition to execution. These imperatives provide the foundation for turning insight into action at scale.

1. INTEGRATE INTELLIGENCE ACROSS TEAMS AND FUNCTIONS

Most teams still operate in silos. Analysts buried in different functions across the business. Marketers flying blind. Engineers speaking a different language to business users. The result? Slow decisions, misaligned KPIs, and fragmented customer experiences. Structuring for intelligence means redesigning teams, workflows, and communication from the ground up.

Leading organisations are:

- **Creating cross-functional intelligence squads**
- **Embedding analysts across business units**
- **Hiring 'storytellers' to bridge insight and action**
- **Ensuring Intelligence leaders have a seat at the 'decision-making table'**

But capability isn't enough. Just 19% of organisations we surveyed qualify as "CX Leaders", i.e. those with codified strategies and strong customer-first cultures, aligned across departments ([Winning in today's experience economy: What CX leaders do differently, Merkle](#)).



Takeaway: Integrated teams make faster, smarter decisions because they're empowered by a single, shared view of the truth.

2. BUILD A CONNECTED INTELLIGENCE STACK

Intelligence requires infrastructure. Data is too often locked in legacy systems or scattered across disconnected tools. A connected stack combines structured and unstructured data to enable self-serve access, predictive modelling, and scenario planning. This is the era of “Big Ops” – managing a spectacular volume and velocity of apps, agents and automations. Intelligence platforms must now unify structured and unstructured data across the stack, enabling orchestration, prediction and decisioning at scale.

But building a connected stack isn't just a technical exercise, it's also about maintaining the integrity of the data itself. Brands need to access more data whilst simultaneously asking where that data comes from, and whether its use is ethical. Trust in your data leads to trust in your decisions.

Our experience shows that businesses with unified stacks are better able to measure customer lifetime value, adapt marketing activity and scale customer-centric decisions. In fact, 87% of CX Leaders measure performance using long-term value metrics, not just tactical KPIs ([Winning in today's experience economy: What CX leaders do differently, Merkle](#)).



Takeaway: A connected stack fuels insight, agility and foresight across the business.



3. INSTIL A CULTURE OF INTELLIGENCE

The right tools and teams will stall without the right mindset. Culture is what turns insight into habit – and ensures intelligence isn't confined to the data team. Intelligence only becomes a competitive edge when it's embedded in how people think, collaborate and make decisions, from the C-Suite to the frontline.

This shift in culture is already paying off for brands that are embracing it. The [DMA's latest report](#) shows that customer data-driven campaigns are 329% more likely to report improvements in customer loyalty, 226% more likely to drive pricing power, and 104% more likely to grow customer lifetime value – all metrics that speak directly to the boardroom.

Today's CX leaders measure what matters. They focus on long-term outcomes and empower every function to use data. Organisations with strong CX maturity are more likely to have shared definitions of customer excellence, integrated data governance, and a clear link between data and decision-making ([Winning in today's experience economy: What CX leaders do differently, Merkle](#)). Leading organisations are also rethinking performance reviews to assess not just delivery, but decision-making. They're investing in AI literacy, removing repetitive tasks, and celebrating the wins that come from smarter, faster action.

Yet many marketers remain stuck: 76% of CMOs say they want exponential growth, but only invest 10% of their budget in innovation ([The Innovation Paradox, dentsu](#)). A cultural shift is needed, towards experimentation, cross-functional planning, and a willingness to act on imperfect information.

Takeaway: Culture is the catalyst. When insight is embedded in everyday behaviour, action becomes instinctive – but change only happens when it comes from the top.





The AI advantage: From automation to agentic intelligence

AI is no longer a future consideration; it's a present-tense accelerant for businesses striving to become intelligence-led. Yet its true value lies not in novelty, but in utility: when AI is embedded into workflows, aligned with business priorities, and used to solve real customer problems.

Across this paper, we've explored the five forces and three imperatives that drive intelligence. Now, we examine how AI acts as the connective tissue across each of them: with the potential to amplify speed, precision, and predictive power at every stage.

1. SCALING ACTIONABLE UNDERSTANDING

AI simplifies and expedites the data pipeline. From anomaly detection to trend recognition, it transforms raw inputs into structured insights in real time. Large language models (LLMs) and generative AI tools now enable teams to synthesise, summarise, and contextualise vast datasets, turning information into immediate understanding.

[Example: AI-powered insight summarisation tools help marketers distil performance data into weekly decision support summaries, reducing the lag between action and optimisation.](#)

2. ENABLING DEEPER AWARENESS

AI helps brands perceive what customers truly value, across signals they willingly give (declared data) and those inferred through behaviour (observed data). Tools like emotion recognition, semantic analysis, and predictive segmentation offer new levels of audience insight.

[Example: AI-enabled audience clustering reveals emerging micro-moments that matter to your most valuable customers, informing content, creative, and campaign strategy with precision.](#)

3. DRIVING STRATEGIC CLARITY

AI supports strategic alignment by surfacing cross-functional priorities, linking activity to outcomes, and testing hypotheses through simulation and scenario modelling. This clarity empowers teams to confidently shift from insight to impact.

Example: Agentic AI copilots in planning tools (e.g. Merkle's Business Planner) proactively recommend spend reallocations based on real-time performance and strategic goals.

4. ENHANCING PREDICTIVE CAPABILITY

From churn prediction to demand forecasting, AI turns historical data and real-time signals into actionable foresight. Agentic systems go further still – making autonomous micro-decisions within defined guardrails to optimise performance.

Example: Retail media platforms use AI to dynamically adjust creative and bidding strategies based on consumer behaviour, inventory changes, and competitor pricing.

5. CREATING COMPETITIVE EDGE

AI increases agility. It automates the routine to free up focus for the strategic. It enables faster test-and-learn cycles. And as capabilities like synthetic data generation and digital twins mature, AI is reshaping how brands innovate.

Example: AI-generated synthetic customer profiles are helping brands safely test marketing scenarios before rolling out campaigns to real audiences, reducing risk and accelerating learning.

The importance of governance and guardrails in responsible AI builds

With great power comes great responsibility. Ethical AI use must be foundational: ensuring data privacy, reducing bias, and building systems that are transparent, accountable, and human-centred. Leading brands are investing in AI governance frameworks, cross-functional ethics boards, and AI literacy to ensure their adoption is both safe and strategic.

As one CDO put it during our recent roundtable: **“It’s not about using AI because we can. It’s about choosing where it adds value, and where human judgement must still lead.”**

What good looks like: Client examples in action

Hearst UK, home to brands like *Cosmopolitan*, *Esquire*, *Elle*, and *Good Housekeeping*, faced a familiar challenge: they had a wealth of customer data, but limited ability to connect it in real time to fuel strategic decision-making. To unlock its potential, Hearst partnered with Merkle to transform their data infrastructure into a cloud-based stack designed to support privacy compliance with applicable regulations, capable of delivering live customer intelligence across the organisation.

The result was a powerful identity resolution platform that delivered a complete, real-time view of subscribers, enabling personalised subscription experiences at scale.

By embedding this intelligence into daily workflows, Hearst improved the efficiency of key data processes by 40x, while fostering a more data-driven, customer-centric culture across teams.

This transformation wasn't just about technology; it was about enabling faster, smarter decisions through connected teams, connected tech, and a culture built on insight.



Looking ahead: A new intelligence mandate

As we approach 2035, according to current industry research and projections, it is anticipated that consumers may expect more intuitive, real-time, and emotionally attuned brand experiences. Nearly half (49%) say they would like an AI clone to handle shopping and admin tasks for them; and 84% want technology that seamlessly overlays digital information on their surroundings ([Consumer Vision 2035, dentsu](#)).

To deliver on this future, marketing and tech leaders must align. CMOs need systems that scale personalisation and intelligence. CTOs need strategic clarity to ensure tech investment drives value. Intelligence is the bridge – and the opportunity.

49%

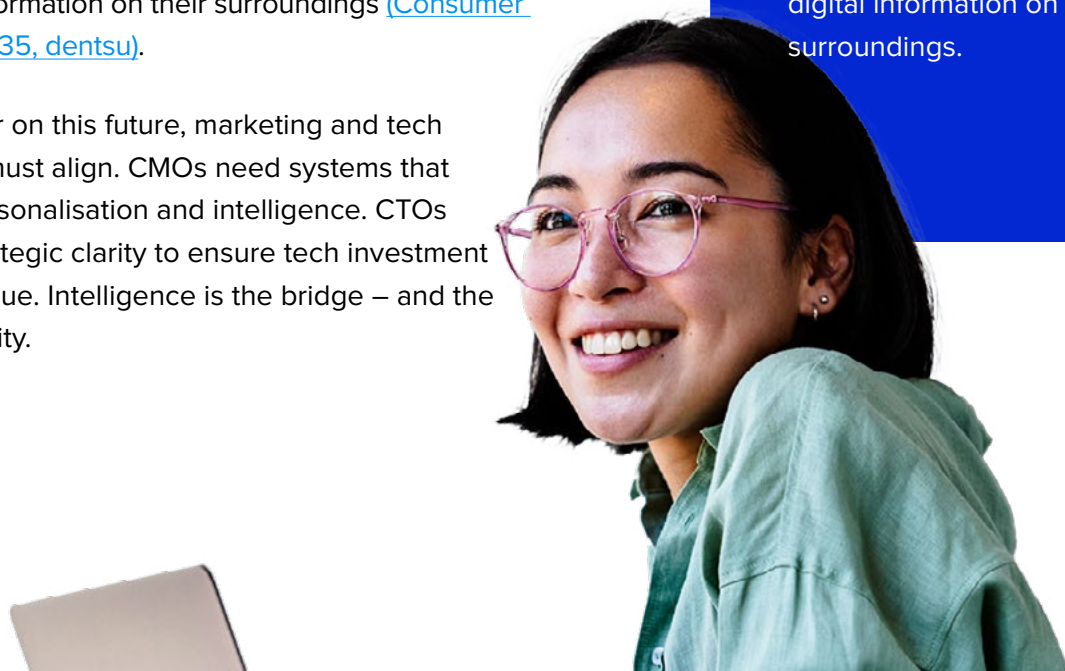
Customers

say they would like an AI clone to handle shopping and admin tasks for them.

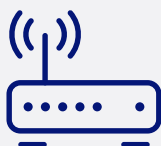
84%

Customers

want technology that seamlessly overlays digital information on their surroundings.



Connected teams



Connected tech



Intelligence culture

From collection to connection: **The time is now**

Winning brands won't just gather more data. They'll collect the *right* data, and turn it into connected, predictive, and actionable intelligence. That's what allows them to meet customer expectations, seize market shifts, and deliver long-term growth.

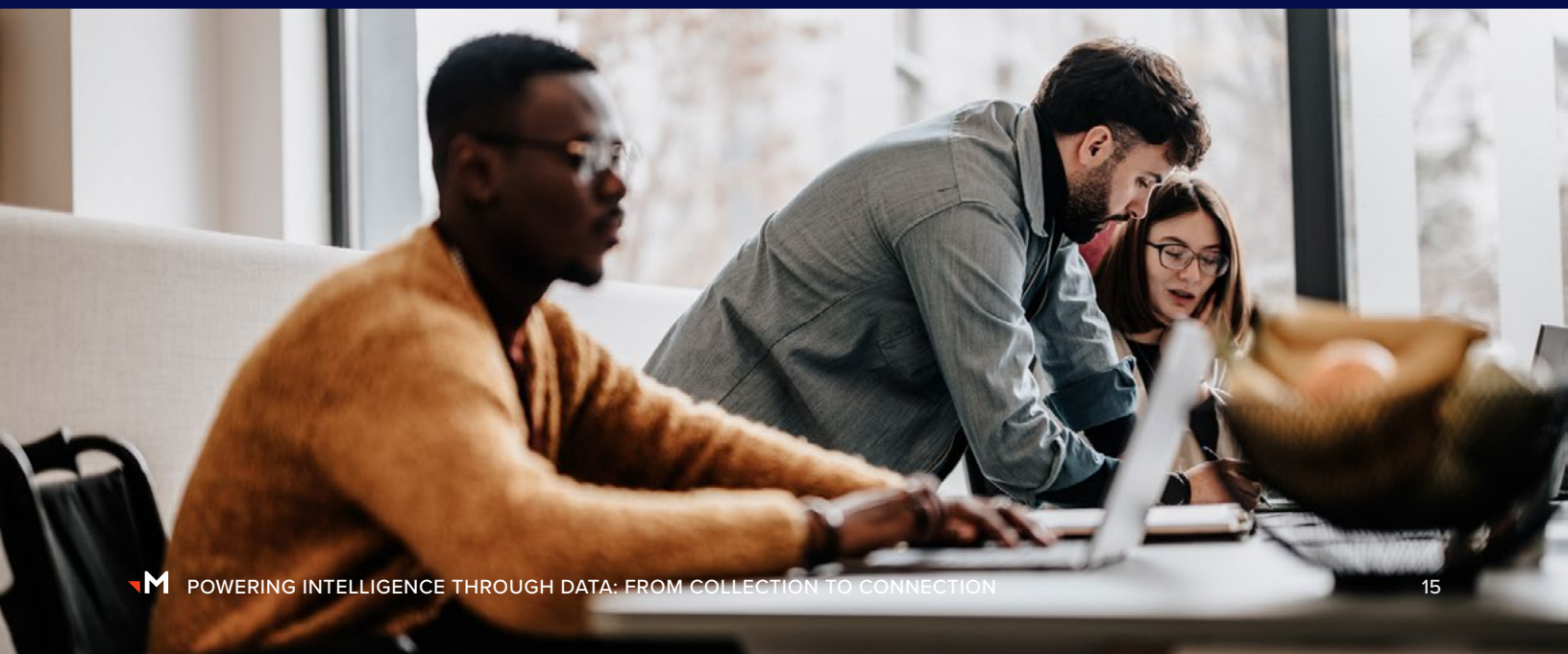
But powering intelligence isn't just about tools or dashboards. It's about creating the conditions where data flows freely, insights inform every decision, and teams are empowered to act with speed and confidence. It requires alignment across people, platforms, and purpose. The most successful organisations aren't waiting for perfect data or future-ready infrastructure. They're building intelligence incrementally, embedding it into everyday workflows, and using it to navigate uncertainty with clarity.

At Merkle, we help businesses build the foundations for an intelligence-led future

-designing integrated workflows, deploying connected stacks, and embedding agentic AI into daily operations. With over 30 years of experience in turning data into decisions, we don't just implement technology; we help shape the operating models, culture, and measurement systems that unlock faster, better choices across marketing and the wider business.

Through open, interoperable tech solutions, deep expertise in identity, and close partnerships with platforms like Google and Meta, we enable end-to-end transformation. Whether it's optimising spend, unifying data, or embedding generative AI into core workflows, we help brands innovate to impact with confidence.

If you're ready to power your brand with intelligence, we're ready to help. [Contact us](#) to learn more.



Author bio

Ben Gott, President UK&I, Data & Technology, dentsu

Ben steers our insights and analytics capabilities across our UK&I business, working to enhance our client data products and platform solutions in line with our global offering.

Driving innovation and supporting our integrated capabilities as One dentsu, Ben leads a team that is responsible for the implementation, integration and management of clients' data and technology – ensuring they are getting the most out of their investments and delivering our UK&I growth strategy.

Ben works closely with the Global, EMEA and UK&I teams, Practice CEOs, Client Leaders, and broader product communities across the Group to create new commercial opportunities. He also collaborates closely with our Innovation leadership team to further dentsu's AI strategy.

During his 15+ year career at Merkle, Ben worked to bring the Agency Service and Marketing Solutions businesses closer together and to empower clients' customer experience transformations through tech. He is a longstanding member of the dentsu family, having joined Periscopix in 2006 ahead of its acquisition by Merkle in 2016. Over the past eight years, Ben has held leadership roles at Merkle EMEA and UK&I, most recently as Chief Data and Marketing Technology Officer.

Kate Amos, Managing Director, Analytics Solutions, Merkle

Kate Amos leads Merkle's Analytics Solutions Practice, helping clients unlock the full potential of their data. Her team sits at the intersection of data strategy and advanced analytics, combining the skills of strategists and analysts to turn complex data into actionable intelligence that drives smarter, faster decisions.

With over 20 years of experience in the data industry, Kate brings deep expertise from both client-side and agency-side roles. She began her career in publishing, managing data solutions for leading brands including the Financial Times, The Guardian, and Reed Elsevier, before moving agency-side to lead major data and analytics programmes for the Post Office, IKEA, and VMO2.

Beyond Merkle, Kate is also Chair of the DMA Social Council, where she helps shape best practices in data-driven social media and champion the responsible use of data across the marketing industry.

About Merkle

Merkle is a leading data-driven customer experience management (CXM) company that specializes in the delivery of unique, personalized customer experiences across platforms and devices. For more than 30 years, Fortune 1000 companies and leading nonprofit organizations have partnered with Merkle to maximize the value of their customer portfolios. The company's heritage in data, technology, and analytics forms the foundation for its unmatched skills in understanding consumer insights that drive hyper-personalized marketing strategies. Its combined strengths in performance media, customer experience, customer relationship management, loyalty, and enterprise marketing technology drive improved marketing results and competitive advantage. With 12,000 employees, Merkle is headquartered in Columbia, Maryland, with 50+ additional offices throughout the Americas, EMEA, and APAC. Merkle is a dentsu company. For more information, contact Merkle at 1-877-9-Merkle or visit www.merkle.com.

About dentsu

Dentsu is an integrated growth and transformation partner to the world's leading organizations. Founded in 1901 in Tokyo, Japan, and now present in approximately 120 countries and regions, it has a proven track record of nurturing and developing innovations, combining the talents of its global network of leadership brands to develop impactful and integrated growth solutions for clients. Dentsu delivers end-to-end experience transformation (EX) by integrating its services across Media, CXM and Creative, while its business transformation (BX) mindset pushes the boundaries of transformation and sustainable growth for brands, people and society.

Dentsu, Innovating to Impact.

Find out more: www.dentsu.com / www.group.dentsu.com

